Bill's Helix Cheat Sheet / Command Reference

1 Introduction

1.1 Metadata

- Document version: 1.1.0-beta, 27-Apr-2026
- Based on Helix version: 25.07.1
- Built with Typst version: 0.14.2
- Distributed at:
  https://github.com/wrwetzel/Helix-Cheat-Sheet
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1.2 Definitions

- **file** - data on storage device, e.g., hard disk or ssd
- **buffers** - data from one or more files loaded into memory
- **view** - one or more visual areas on screen showing one or more buffers
- **workspace** - the directory from which Helix was launched
- **under selection** - the entire word containing the cursor
- **alternate buffer** - the previous active buffer
- **textual line** - text as defined by the newline character
- **visual line** - what appears on screen after word-wrapping
- **range** - a selection; one in single-selection, multiple in multi-selection

1.3 Typographic Conventions

- **`word`** - alphanumeric, punctuation-delimited
- **`WORD`** - whitespace-delimited
- **`Ctrl-c`** - Ctrl and c key pressed simultaneous.
- **`Alt-c`** - Alt and c key pressed simultaneous.
- Some Alt and Ctrl characters may conflict with terminal capture and require terminal configuration change.
- **`␣c`** is space followed by the character c.
- Metavars **`<regex>`**, **`<file>`** and **`<ch>`** represent user input. The angle-brackets are not part of the input.
- **`␣`**, **`<minus>`**, and **`<under>`** used for clarity. **`<enter>`**, **`<del>`**, **`<bksp>`**, etc. used for non-printing control characters.
- Commands are separated from definitions by a dash. Synonyms are separated by commas. Related commands are separated by slashes. The separators are never part of the command though commands may include a dash, comma, or slash.

1.4 Launching

```
helix
helix <file>
helix <file1> <file2> ... <filen>
helix <directory>
helix --help
hx in some distributions or by alias
```

2 Primary Commands

2.1 Editing Paradigm

Selection first, action second. *mode* and *count* are optional.

```
[mode][count][select][command]
```

`v3wd` – enter select mode, select 3 words, delete

2.2 Regular Expressions

Helix uses Rust's regex. Escape following metachars with <backslash> when searching for literal value.

2.4.3 By Treesitter - Syntax

Requires Treesitter support.

```
]f, [f – to next, prior function
]t, [t – to next, prior type defin
]T, [T – to next, prior test
]a, [a – to next, prior arg
]c, [c – to next, prior comment
]g, [g – to next, prior change
]G, [G – to last, first change
Alt-e – move to end of parent n
Alt-b – move to start of parent
```

2.4.4 By Page

```
Ctrl-b – page up
Ctrl-f – page down
Ctrl-u – half page up
Ctrl-d – half page down
```

2.5 Selection

Selection: a range of characters between ancho
Normal Mode: move and select
Select Mode: move and extend selection

2.5.1 Operations

```
% – select whole file
Alt-; – swap anchor and cursor
Alt-: – selection to normal dire
Alt-o – expand selection syntax
Alt-i – shrink selection
; – collapse selection(s) to c
```

2.5.2 By TextObjects

```
ma<ch> / mi<ch> – match around / inside t
w / W – word / WORD
p – paragraph
(, [, ', etc.– specified surround pair
m – closest surround pair
f – function
t – type or class
a – argument/parameter
c – comment
T – test
g – change git hunk
```

2.5.3 By Syntactic Objects

```
w / W – to start of next word / W
e / E – to end of current word /
b / B – to start of current word
x – current line, extend by l
X – extend to line
Alt-x – shrink to line bounds
]p – to next paragraph
[p – to prior paragraph
```

2.5.4 By Treesitter - Syntax

Requires Treesitter support.

```
Alt-o – expand selection to pare
Alt-i – shrink syntax tree objec
Alt-p – select previous sibling n
```

```
          . – any character
          * – zero or more
          + – one or more
          ? – zero or one / lazy match
          ^ – start of line / negation in class
          $ – end of line
        ( ) – capture group
        [ ] – character class
        { } – repetition count
          | – alternation
          \ – escape character itself
```

2.3 Essentials

2.3.1 Undo / Repeat / Normal Mode

```
        u / U – undo / redo change in linear history
Alt-u / Alt-U – move backward / forward in tree history
  :ear / :lat – move backward / forward in history by step count or time span (1s,
                2m, 3h, 4d)
    <nn><cmd> – repeat <cmd> <nn> times
          Esc – return to normal mode
```

2.3.2 Quit

Add **!** suffix to force operation.

```
          :wq – write current buffer and quit
    :wq <file> – write current buffer to <file> and quit
         :wqa – write all buffer(s) and quit
           :q – quit current buffer, exits if last
```

2.3.3 Files

```
     :o <file> – open <file> in new buffer
     :w <file> – write current buffer to <file>

    :hs <file> – open/create <file> in new horizontal split
    :vs <file> – open/create <file> in new vertical split
          ␣wf – open/create file(s) under selection(s) in horizontal split
          ␣wF – open/create file(s) under selection(s) in vertical split
           gf – open/create file(s) under selection, open url under selection.

           ␣f – open file picker at LSP workspace root
           ␣F – open file picker at current working directory
           ␣g – open changed file picker
```

2.3.3.1 File Picker

All pickers, here and elsewhere, are *fuzzy* - they tolerate gaps in the input, ranking closer matches higher.

```
       <enter> – open selected in current view
        Ctrl-s – open selected in new horizontal split
        Ctrl-v – open selected in new vertical split
```

2.3.4 Buffers

Add **!** suffix to force operation. Buffers named by file they contain.

```
           :n – create new scratch buffer
          :bc – close current buffer
         :bca – close all buffers
         :bco – close all but current buffer
          :bn – next buffer
           ␣b – open buffer picker

           ga – go to last accessed/alternate buffer
           gm – go to last modified/alternate buffer
           gn – go to next buffer
           gp – go to previous buffer
```

2.3.5 Views

```
          Alt-n – select next sibling node
          Alt-a – select all sibling nodes i
          Alt-I – select all children nodes
```

2.5.5 By Character Value

Lower case: forward
Upper case: backward

```
   f<ch>, F<ch> – to <ch> inclusive (find)
   t<ch>, T<ch> – to <ch> exclusive (till)
        Alt-.  – repeat last find / till
```

2.6 Select Mode

Movement: extends selection
Search: adds to selection

```
             v – toggle select mode
           Esc – return to normal
             ) – cycle primary selection
             ( – cycle primary selection
        Alt-,  – remove primary selectio
```

2.7 Multiple Selections

Multiple independent cursors / selections, one

2.7.1 Creating

Create multiple selections from selection.

```
       s<regex> – matches become selecti
              S – split on match
         Alt-s – split on newlines
     C / Alt-C – add selection below / ab
```

2.7.2 Operations

```
              & – align on primary cursor
   Alt-<minus> – merge selections
   Alt-<under> – merge consecutive selec
             , – remove all except prima
        Alt-,  – remove primary selectio
         ( / ) – rotate primary backwar
  Alt-( / Alt-) – rotate content backwar
              K – keep selections matchin
          Alt-K – remove selections matc
```

2.8 Alter Buffer Content

2.8.1 Insert

```
              i – before selection
              a – after selection
              I – at start of line
              A – at end of line
              o – add line and insert belo
              O – add line and insert abov
            Esc – end insert (return to no
              . – repeat last insert
```

2.8.2 Add

```
             ]␣ – newline below
             [␣ – newline above
       ms<ch> – add delim <ch> around s
```

2.8.3 Delete

```
              d – selection -> yank buf, de
```

Ctrl-w and ␣w are synonymous.

```
  ␣ws / ␣wv  – split horizontal / vertical, current buffer
 ␣wns / ␣wnv – split horizontal / vertical, new buffer
         ␣wq – close current split
         ␣wo – close all but current split
         ␣ww – next split

   ␣wh/j/k/l – move to buffer left / up / down / right
   ␣wH/J/K/L – swap split with buffer on left / up / down / right
         ␣wt – transpose split
```

2.3.5.1 View Movement

Commands shown with **z** prefix. The prefix is not used in sticky mode, which is a view-only navigation mode appropriate for browsing a file without editing.

```
           Z – enter sticky mode, exit with Esc

       zz, zc – align to center
           zt – align to top
           zb – align to bottom
           zm – align to middle horizontally
           zj – scroll down
           zk – scroll up
```

2.3.6 Help

```
      :tutor – open tutorial
          ␣? – open command palette
```

2.4 Movement

2.4.1 Cursor Movement

Normal Mode: motion replaces selection
Select Mode: motion extends selection

```
      h/j/k/l – left / up / down / right
       gh, g| – beginning of line
       <nn>g| – column <nn>
           gl – end of line
           gg – top of file
<nn>G, g<nn>g – line <nn>
           ge – bottom of file
           gw – two-char labels on words, label to go to word

           g.– to last modification in current file
           gj – down textual line
           gk – up textual line

           gs – first non-white-space char
           gt – top of screen
           gc – middle of screen
           gb – bottom of screen
```

2.4.2 By Language Server Protocol

Requires LSP support.

```
           gd – go to definition
           gy – go to type definition
           gr – go to references
           gi – go to implementation

           ]d – next diagnostic
           [d – prior diagnostic
           ]D – last diagnostic
           [D – first diagnostic
```

```
       Alt-d – delete, no save
    md<ch> – delete delim <ch> aroun
```

2.8.4 Change

```
           c – selection -> yank buf, ch
      Alt-c – change, no save
           = – format by LSP
mr<ch1><ch2> – replace delim <ch1> with
```

2.8.5 Indent Lines

```
           > – Indent line(s) containing
           < – Undent line(s) containin
```

2.8.6 Change Case

Change case of all letters in selection

```
           ~ – change case
           ` – set lowercase
      Alt-` – set uppercase
```

2.8.7 Comments

All apply to selection.

```
  ␣c, Ctrl-c – Toggle comment
          ␣C – Toggle block comment
     ␣Alt-C – Toggle line comment
```

2.8.8 Increment / Decrement

```
    Ctrl-a – increment the selected
    Ctrl-x – decrement the selected
```

2.8.9 Miscellaneous

```
           J – join lines in a selection
     Alt-J – join lines inside selecti
   <under> – trim whitespace from s
:reflow <width> – wrap selection to <widt
     :sort – sort ranges in selection
   :format – format file using extern
```

2.9 Copy / Paste / Replace

```
           y – selection -> yank buf
           p – paste yank buf after the
           P – paste yank buf before th
          ␣y – yank selection(s) -> syste
          ␣Y – yank main selection -> s
    ␣p / ␣P – paste clipboard after / b
          ␣R – replace selection(s) with
       r<ch> – replace selection with <c
           R – replace selection with y
           " – select register to yank t
```

ition

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node in syntax tree

or and cursor

ction (cursor at end)
-aware

ursor(s)

the object indicated by <ch> below:

rs

WORD
WORD
/ WORD
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ent syntax node
ct selection
node in syntax tree

2.10 Search

```
/<regex> – search forward for regex
?<regex> – search backward for regex
    n, N – next, previous match
       * – search for current selection, respect word boundaries
    Alt-* – search for current selection
```

2.11 Registers

Identified by single char <ch>

```
  "<ch> – change to reg <ch>
 "<ch>y – yank into reg <ch>
 "<ch>p – paste from reg <ch>
 "<ch>R – replace with reg <ch>
```

2.12 Macros

```
 "<ch>Q – toggle capture to reg <ch>, default @
 "<ch>q – play macro in reg <ch>, default @
```

2.13 Jumplists

```
 Ctrl-s – save current position to jumplist
 Ctrl-i – move forward in jumplist
 Ctrl-o – move backwards in jumplist
     ␣j – open jumplist picker
```

2.14 Match Mode

With regard to balanced delimiters.

```
       mm – go to matching delim
 mi<ch> – match inside delim <ch>
 ma<ch> – match around delim <ch>
 ms<ch> – add delim <ch> around selection
 md<ch> – delete delim <ch> around selection
mr<ch1><ch2> – replace delim <ch1> with <ch2>
```

2.15 Shell

All commands pipe each selection to shell command.

```
      | – replace selection(s) with output
 Alt-| – ignore output
      ! – insert output before each selection(s)
 Alt-! – append output after each selection(s)
      $ – keep selection(s) where command returned 0
```

2.16 Approaching an IDE

```
 ␣G – debug - experimental
 ␣k – show documentation for item under cursor
 ␣s – open document symbol picker
 ␣S – open workspace symbol picker
 ␣d – open document diagnostics picker
 ␣D – open workspace diagnostics picker
 ␣r – rename symbol
 ␣a – apply code action
 ␣h – select symbol references for symbol under cursor
```

2.17 Editor Configuration

```
:config-open – open the config file
:config-open-workspace – open the workspace config file
```

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n syntax tree
s in syntax tree

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selection

lete selection

```
.config-open-workspace – open the workspace config file
        :config-reload – reload the config file
```

2.18 Miscellaneous

```
            ␣' – open last picker
            ␣/ – open global search in workspace folder picker
```

3 Commands in Specific Contexts

3.1 Insert Mode Editing

Navigation keys shown.

```
                                Ctrl-s – commit undo checkpoint
                                Ctrl-x – autocomplete
                                Ctrl-r – insert a register content
                   Ctrl-w, Alt-<bksp> – delete previous word
                     Alt-d, Alt-<del> – delete next word
                                Ctrl-u – delete to start of line
                                Ctrl-k – delete to end of line
         Ctrl-h, <bksp>, Shift-<bksp> – delete previous char
                       Ctrl-d, <del> – delete next char
                     Ctrl-j, <enter> – insert new line
       <Up>, <Down>, <Left>, <Right>,– usual meaning but discouraged
  <PageUp>, <PageDown>, <Home>, <End>
```

3.2 Command Line Editing

```
        Esc, Ctrl-c – close prompt
            <enter> – open selected
              <tab> – select next completion item
          <backtab> – select previous completion item
              Alt-b – backward a word
             Ctrl-b – backward a char
              Alt-f – forward a word
             Ctrl-f – forward a char
             Ctrl-e – to prompt end
             Ctrl-a – to prompt start
Ctrl-w, Ctrl-<bksp> – delete previous word
  Alt-d, Ctrl-<del> – delete next word
             Ctrl-u – delete to start of line
             Ctrl-k – delete to end of line
     <bksp>, Ctrl-h – delete previous char
      <del>, Ctrl-d – delete next char
             Ctrl-s – insert a word under doc cursor (may be changed to Ctrl-r Ctrl-
                      w later)
             Ctrl-p – select previous history
             Ctrl-n – select next history
             Ctrl-r – insert the content of the register selected by following input
                      char
```

3.3 Pickers

Navigation keys shown.

```
Shift-<tab>, Ctrl-p, <Up> – previous entry
    <tab>, Ctrl-n, <Down> – next entry
                  <Home> – to first entry
                   <End> – to last entry
         Ctrl-u, <PageUp> – page up
       Ctrl-d, <PageDown> – page down
                  <enter> – open selected
             Alt-<enter> – open selected in the background without closing the
                           picker
                   Ctrl-s – open horizontally
                   Ctrl-v – open vertically
                   Ctrl-t – toggle preview
             Esc, Ctrl-c – close picker
```

3.4 Popups

Displays documentation for item under cursor.

d selection

ange selection

n <ch2>

g selection
g selection

number
number

on and select the inserted space
selection
th>, default 80
n
nal formatter / language server

cursor
e cursor
em clipboard
system clipboard
efore selections(s)
clipboard
ch>
ank buf
o or paste from

```
      Ctrl-u – scroll up
      Ctrl-d – scroll down
```

3.5 Completion Menu

Displays documentation for the selected completion item. Any other keypresses result in the completion being accepted.

```
Shift-Tab, Ctrl-p – previous entry
      Tab, Ctrl-n – next entry
         <enter> – close menu and accept completion
          Ctrl-c – close menu and reject completion
```

3.6 Signature-help Popup

Displays the signature of the selected completion item.

```
        Alt-p – previous signature
        Alt-n – next signature
```